We had a lovely time that summer. Joe and his friends put us up in a nice hotel. We'd wake up in the morning and someone would be there to take us wherever we wanted to go: down to the beach, into the village, or round the island. It was a great set-up and the Maltese loved their soccer. The next summer I went back with Cas, Gary and Ben Thornley. It was a lads' vacation; or, at least, as laddish as it was ever going to get with us—a couple of beers and a little romance but nothing you'd need to keep a secret from your mum.

We'd told Joe beforehand not to book us a fancy hotel or anything, although when we got to our apartment block we wished we hadn't mentioned anything. The place was terrible. There was no air-conditioning and Malta, in the summer, is stifling hot. Gary and Ben grabbed the one room that had a fan in it and Cas and I just sweated away, all day and all night. Those were really good times, though. I loved it so much I went back the next six summers on the trot. Gary even got himself his own place over there.

The four of us used to knock about in Manchester, too, along with Dave Gardner, who was younger than us but always knew the best places to go. Our regular night out together was on a Wednesday, usually to a place called Johnsons, which was in the center of town but slightly tucked away. We were sensible lads—Ben, I suppose, was the most outgoing—and we knew when to stop; when to go home and when to get out of a place if it seemed dodgy. We also had Gary with us, who's one of the most paranoid people ever. He'd drive us mad sometimes. We'd all walk into a place, then turn round and see Gary, standing there bolt upright.

'No, lads. I'm not comfortable here. We've got to get out. Come on, we've got to get out.'

All it would take would be one funny look from someone. In a way it was good, because it meant we never had a whiff of trouble. Later, we'd all end up at Ben's to stay the night. He was still living with his parents and his room was right up at the top of the house: a big room but absolutely freezing. Ben, of course, would be tucked up cozy in his bed. Me, Gary and Cas would be lying on the floor, shivering. I miss those nights out: I couldn't do anything like that now, after all.

Like all young players, we had our jobs to do around the training ground. I remember Cas and I being put on the first-team dressing room, which meant we had to scrub the baths and showers and clean the dressing room itself. I got in there first and got the easy half of it: got my shorts on and just splashed